

Towards Self-Understanding

An exhaustive academic monograph investigating the epistemology of reflective practice (Donald Schön, John Dewey, Graham Gibbs), the psychological architecture of self-concept, self-esteem, and teacher self-efficacy (Albert Bandura, Julian Rotter), the neurobiology of occupational stress and burnout prevention, philosophical traditions of self-realization (Srimanta Sankardeva, Sri Sri Madhabdeva, Swami Vivekananda, Sri Aurobindo, Jiddu Krishnamurti), personal and institutional SWOT diagnostics, the World Health Organization (WHO) ten core life skills, the Johari Window model of interpersonal transparency, barriers to authentic educational communication, professional ethics, mindfulness neuroscience, Daniel Goleman's Emotional Intelligence (EQ) framework, and Kristin Neff's self-compassion model.

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● Curriculum Session 2026 • Exhaustive Master Reference Edition

CURRICULUM ARCHITECTURE & CONTINUOUS INTERNAL ASSESSMENT BLUEPRINT

Total:
50 Internal Marks

Unit 1

15 Marks

Reflective Writing Tasks

Epistemology of Introspection, Donald Schön, Self-Concept & Bandura's Efficacy, Stress Neurobiology, Sankardeva & Vivekananda.

Unit 2

15 Marks

Growth & Life Skills Workshops

Personal & Institutional SWOT Matrix, WHO 10 Life Skills, Johari Window Dynamics, Communication 7 Cs, Mindfulness.

Unit 3

10 Marks

Humane Qualities & EQ Seminars

Carl Rogers' Humanism (UPR), Daniel Goleman's 5 EQ Domains, Social Grace & Soft Skills, Kristin Neff's Self-Compassion.

SIP-I Link

10 Marks

Field Practice & Portfolio

Reflective Journal Portfolio, School Internship Life Skills Delivery, Case Diagnostics & Mentor Evaluations.

1

Reflective Writing Tasks for Self-Awareness

Epistemology of Introspection, The Reflective Practitioner, Self-Efficacy Constructs & Spiritual Traditions

Weightage:
15 Marks (5 × 3)

In contemporary teacher education, **Self-Understanding** is recognized as the indispensable affective prerequisite for pedagogical competence. Teaching is an intensely relational human encounter; an educator who lacks conscious awareness of their own emotional triggers, unexamined prejudices, defense mechanisms, and philosophical values inevitably projects unresolved anxieties onto vulnerable children.

Self-reflective writing is not casual diary-keeping or self-indulgent brooding. It is a disciplined, metacognitive inquiry through which an educator develops what ancient Indian psychology termed the *Sakshi Bhava* (the impartial "Inner Witness") and what Western educational philosopher Donald Schön codified as **The Reflective Practitioner**.

- **REFLECTION-ON-ACTION (SCHÖN)**

Retrospective critical analysis occurring *after* a pedagogical episode has concluded. The teacher reviews classroom events: *"Why did the storytelling session collapse into disorder? What subtle anxiety was I projecting that prompted the students' restlessness?"*

Temporal Orientation: Post-Event Synthesis
- **REFLECTION-IN-ACTION (SCHÖN)**

Metacognitive mindfulness occurring *in real time* during classroom transactions. The teacher monitors somatic cues (tightening chest, rising vocal pitch), identifies surge of frustration, and consciously adjusts pacing or tone without punitive reactivity.

Temporal Orientation: Real-Time Self-Regulation
- **REFLECTION-FOR-ACTION (KILLION & TODNEM)**

Proactive strategic planning linking past self-knowledge to future classroom design. The teacher modifies pedagogical interventions to preempt recognized vulnerabilities, ensuring continuous professional growth.

Temporal Orientation: Proactive Evolution

● **GRAHAM GIBBS' REFLECTIVE CYCLE (1988) FOR STUDENT-TEACHER JOURNALS:**

ITERATIVE STAGE	PSYCHOLOGICAL FUNCTION	ILLUSTRATIVE TRAINEE REFLECTION

1. Description	Objective, non-judgmental factual account of the specific classroom incident.	<i>"During math circle time, Rohan repeatedly banged his slate on the bench while I was demonstrating place-value bundles."</i>
2. Feelings	Unvarnished identification of subjective emotional states and visceral reactions.	<i>"I felt a sharp surge of professional inadequacy and irritation. I feared the visiting mentor would judge me as an incompetent disciplinarian."</i>
3. Evaluation	Dispassionate appraisal of what worked effectively and what went wrong.	<i>"I succeeded in keeping my voice level, but failed by ignoring Rohan's sensory overload from sitting on a wet concrete floor."</i>
4. Analysis	Integrating theoretical developmental concepts to make sense of the episode.	<i>"Applying Piaget, Rohan is in the preoperational stage; my 20-minute lecture on place value was abstract and developmentally inappropriate."</i>
5. Conclusion	Crystallizing general lessons and identifying personal growth edges.	<i>"I learned that my irritation was driven by my own insecurity about mentor evaluation, rather than Rohan's natural motor restlessness."</i>
6. Action Plan	Formulating concrete, observable behavioral adjustments for future practice.	<i>"Next week, I will introduce place value using tangible matchstick bundles on floor mats, giving kinetic roles to active students."</i>

1.2

"Understanding Oneself is Power": Psychological Constructs of the Self

Psychological Foundations

The classical philosophical dictum—*"Knowing others is intelligence; knowing yourself is true wisdom. Mastering others is strength; mastering yourself is true power"* (Lao Tzu)—serves as a core tenet of educator mental health. Contemporary cognitive-developmental psychology anchors self-understanding in four interrelated constructs:

● SELF-CONCEPT & SELF-ESTEEM (WILLIAM JAMES & CARL ROGERS)

Self-Concept is the multi-dimensional cognitive schema an individual holds about their attributes, competencies, and identity (answering: "Who am I?"). **Self-Esteem** is the affective, evaluative judgment of personal worth based on that self-concept (answering: "How do I feel about who I am?").

Carl Rogers demonstrated that psychological distress arises when a wide disparity emerges between the **Real Self** (who one actually is) and the **Ideal Self** (the perfectionist standard one feels compelled to be). Trainees who accept their fallibility exhibit higher empathy toward struggling students.

● TEACHER SELF-EFFICACY (ALBERT BANDURA'S SOCIAL COGNITIVE THEORY)

Bandura defined **Self-Efficacy** as an individual's subjective conviction in their capability to organize and execute courses of action required to produce designated achievements. **Teacher Self-Efficacy** is the educator's belief that their instruction can positively influence student learning, even among difficult, unmotivated, or marginalized children.

Bandura proved self-efficacy is constructed through four distinct sources: (1) *Mastery Experiences* (past teaching successes), (2) *Vicarious Experiences* (observing mentor teachers succeed), (3) *Social Persuasion* (constructive coaching feedback), and (4) *Physiological/Emotional States* (managing anxiety).

● JULIAN ROTTER'S LOCUS OF CONTROL FRAMEWORK

Rotter categorized individuals along a continuum based on where they perceive the primary causal agents of their life events:

External Locus of Control (বাহ্যিক নিয়ন্ত্রণ):

Attributing student failure exclusively to uncontrollable environmental forces (e.g., poverty, illiterate parents, lack of electricity, unsupportive headmasters). Generates pedagogical fatalism, cynicism, and passive resignation.

Internal Locus of Control (অভ্যন্তরীণ নিয়ন্ত্রণ):

Recognizing systemic constraints while focusing relentlessly on personal instructional agency: "What innovative concrete TLM, modified pacing, or emotional reassurance can I introduce today to assist this learner?" Drives pedagogical resilience.

1.3

Deconstructing Teacher Stress, The Neurobiology of Burnout & Somatic Regulation

Occupational
Health

Teaching is classified by occupational psychologists as an emotionally demanding profession. Chronic unmanaged classroom stress triggers the biological **Hypothalamic-Pituitary-Adrenal (HPA) Axis**, elevating systemic cortisol and catecholamines, impairing prefrontal cognitive processing, and producing clinical **Teacher Burnout** (defined by Christina Maslach across three dimensions: *Emotional Exhaustion*, *Depersonalization*, and *Reduced Personal Accomplishment*).

1. COGNITIVE REFRAMING (CBT)

Separating objective classroom stimuli from catastrophic cognitive distortions (Albert Ellis' ABC Model: Activating Event → Irrational Belief → Consequence). Reframing *"This student is deliberately disrespecting me"* into *"This student is communicating unexpressed distress through disruptive movement"* de-escalates amygdala hijack.

Cognitive Architecture: Amygdala Downregulation

2. SOMATIC VAGAL ANCHORING

Utilizing Stephen Porges' **Polyvagal Theory**. When stress activates the sympathetic fight-or-flight cascade, an educator uses voluntary diaphragmatic respiration (4-second inhale, 7-second retain, 8-second exhale) to stimulate the ventral vagus nerve, immediately restoring autonomic parasympathetic calm and vocal prosody.

Physiological Pathway: Vagus Nerve Stimulation

3. BOUNDARY SETTING & RENEWAL

Establishing clear professional boundaries between institutional workload and private emotional life. Preventing compassion fatigue through restorative hobbies, nature immersion, physical exercise, and regular peer support dialogue.

Psychological Hygiene: Burnout Prophylaxis

1.4

Exemplars of Self-Realization, Inner Harmony & Educational Reform

Philosophical
Traditions

Modern reflective pedagogy draws from rich classical Indian philosophical traditions that conceptualized education primarily as an inner journey toward self-realization (*Atma-Jnana*):

1. MAHAPURUSH SRIMANTA SANKARDEVA (1449–1568)

Spearheaded the Neo-Vaishnavite cultural renaissance in Assam through *Eka Sarana Nama Dharma*. Sankardeva modeled self-realization by demolishing rigid caste stratifications, demonstrating that all human beings share divine consciousness.

Established the community **Namghar** as a socio-spiritual democracy where collective congregational singing (*Nama-Kirtana*), drama (*Ankiya Naat*), and dialogue fostered collective emotional catharsis and social equality.

2. SRI SRI MADHABDEVA (1489–1596)

Sankardeva's foremost disciple and author of the monumental *Nama Ghosha* (the "Book of Thousand Verses"). Exemplified selfless humility, master-disciple devotion, and complete dissolution of the ego (*Ahamkara*).

Taught that true knowledge is not academic pride, but deep ethical surrender in service to humanity, illustrating the psychological transition from selfish isolation to universal compassion.

3. SWAMI VIVEKANANDA (1863–1902)

Defined education as: "*The manifestation of the perfection already in man.*" Maintained that knowledge is inherent within the human mind; teaching is uncovering that inner light through concentrated meditation (*Raja Yoga*).

Advocated "**Man-Making and Character-Building Education**" rooted in moral fearlessness (*Abhiih*), physical vigor, and selfless service (*Seva*).

4. SRI AUROBINDO & JIDDU KRISHNAMURTI

Sri Aurobindo formulated *Integral Education*, nurturing five aspects of the human personality: the physical, vital, mental, psychic, and spiritual sheaths.

Jiddu Krishnamurti posited that education without self-knowledge leads to destruction. He advocated **Choiceless Awareness**—observing one's conditioned thoughts, fears, and ambitions without judgment, allowing the mind to transform into an instrument of clarity.

Experiential Workshops for Personal & Professional Growth

Weightage:
15 Marks (5 × 3)

SWOT Diagnostics, WHO Life Skills Framework, Johari Window Dynamics & Mindfulness Neuroscience

2.1

Personal and Institutional SWOT Analysis: Strategic Diagnostic Auditing

Diagnostic
Instrument

Adapted from strategic management, **SWOT Analysis** serves as a reflective diagnostic instrument for teacher trainees. It systematically maps the interplay between **internal subjective capabilities** (Strengths & Weaknesses) and **external objective realities** (Opportunities & Threats):

DIAGNOSTIC
DIMENSION

INTERNAL FACTORS
(WITHIN PERSONAL
CONTROL)

EXTERNAL FACTORS
(ENVIRONMENTAL MILIEU)

Positive Factors (Favorable Dynamics)	STRENGTHS (সবলতাসমূহ): • Natural empathy, vocal modulation, and patience with slow learners. • Fluent bilingual dexterity across Assamese, Bengali, and English. • Creative knack for designing zero-cost teaching-learning aids (TLMs).	OPPORTUNITIES (সুযোগসমূহ): • Access to DIKSHA, NISHTHA, and digital professional webinars. • Supportive mentorship from senior school head teachers during SIP-I. • Community willingness to share indigenous folklore and crafts.
Negative Factors (Challenging Obstacles)	WEAKNESSES (দুর্বলতাসমূহ): • Stage anxiety and voice shaking during morning school assemblies. • Difficulty maintaining calm discipline during noisy group transitions. • Procrastination in updating comprehensive assessment portfolios.	THREATS (প্রত্যাহ্বানসমূহ): • Seasonal monsoon floods disrupting primary school attendance in char areas. • Extreme multi-grade classroom crowding (1 teacher : 60 students). • Cynicism and resistance to play-based pedagogy from traditional staff.

The Strategic Action Equation:

$$\text{Max}\{\text{Strengths} \times \text{Opportunities}\} \quad \text{and} \quad \text{Min}\{\text{Weaknesses} \times \text{Threats}\}$$

A mature student-teacher does not lament their weaknesses; they systematically formulate professional action plans to convert liabilities into developmental assets through targeted workshop participation.

2.2 The World Health Organization (WHO) Ten Core Life Skills Framework

Global
Standards

The World Health Organization (WHO) defines **Life Skills** as the abilities for adaptive and positive behavior that enable individuals to deal effectively with the demands and challenges of everyday life. These ten skills operate across three interconnected psychological domains:

DOMAIN CLUSTER	PAIRED CORE LIFE SKILLS	PRIMARY CLASSROOM PEDAGOGICAL MANIFESTATION

1. Cognitive Thinking Skills (জ্ঞানমূলক কৌশল)	Critical Thinking ↔ Creative Thinking	• <i>Critical</i>: Guiding students to evaluate historical narratives, analyze gender stereotypes in folktales, and question scientific anomalies. • <i>Creative</i>: Encouraging children to invent original story endings and construct indigenous toys from discarded materials.
	Decision Making ↔ Problem Solving	• <i>Decision Making</i>: Evaluating alternative solutions during peer disputes and selecting mutually respectful behavioral choices. • <i>Problem Solving</i>: Deconstructing complex mathematical word problems into manageable sequential steps using concrete counters.
2. Interpersonal Social Skills (পারস্পরিক সামাজিক কৌশল)	Effective Communication ↔ Interpersonal Relationships	• <i>Communication</i>: Articulating instructions with warmth, active listening without interruption, and interpreting children's non-verbal gestures. • <i>Relationships</i>: Building caring teacher-student rapport, facilitating cooperative team games, and eliminating classroom bullying.
	Empathy (সহানুভূতি)	Stepping into the shoes of a child who arrives hungry or traumatized from seasonal flooding; withholding harsh punishment and offering emotional support.
3. Affective Emotional Skills (ভারাত্মক কৌশল)	Coping with Emotions ↔ Coping with Stress	• <i>Emotions</i>: Recognizing anger or inadequacy surges during classroom chaos; modeling verbal expression of frustration without physical shouting. • <i>Stress</i>: Practicing brief relaxation and breathing routines before high-stakes lessons, avoiding teacher burnout.

2.3 &
2.4

The Johari Window Model and Breaking Educational Communication Barriers

Interpersonal
Dynamics

The Johari Window (Joseph Luft & Harry Ingham, 1955):

A cognitive psychological model mapping interpersonal awareness across four quadrants:

1. OPEN / ARENA

Known to Self & Others

Shared pedagogical beliefs, public behaviors, transparent expectations.

2. BLIND SPOT

Unknown to Self, Known to Others

Unconscious speech habits, sarcastic tone, or favoritism spotted by peers.

3. HIDDEN / FAÇADE

Known to Self, Unknown to Others

Private anxieties, imposter feelings, vulnerabilities concealed from colleagues.

4. UNKNOWN

Unknown to Self & Others

Latent potentials, unrecognized creative talents, deep subconscious drives.

The Goal of Teacher Training Workshops:

Expand the **Open Arena** by soliciting non-defensive peer feedback (reducing the Blind Spot) and practicing appropriate professional disclosure (reducing the Façade).

Overcoming Communication Barriers in School:

Classroom communication often falters across four major hurdles:

• **Physical Barriers:** Acoustic reverberation in tin-roofed school sheds, loud street noise, inadequate lighting.

• **Psychological Barriers:** Authoritarian teacher intimidation inducing affective mutism in children; emotional defensiveness.

• **Linguistic / Semantic Barriers:** Teacher using rigid bookish Sanskritized or standard terminology that alienates children speaking regional dialects (e.g., Deshi, Sadri).

• **Socio-Cultural Barriers:** Entrenched gender and social status hierarchies discouraging girls and marginalized children from asking spontaneous questions.

The 7 Cs of Effective Teacher Discourse:

Clear • Concise • Concrete • Correct • Coherent • Complete • Courteous.

2.5 &
2.6

Professional Ethics, Teacher Accountability and The Neuroscience of Mindfulness

Professional
Integrity

Teacher Professional Ethics & Moral Code:

Professional ethics is not passive compliance with administrative surveillance; it is an internal moral commitment governing conduct across three spheres:

1. Duty Towards Students:

Guaranteed non-discrimination (caste, religion, gender, language); absolute eradication of corporal punishment and verbal humiliation (Section 17, RTE Act); protecting child dignity and confidentiality.

2. Duty Towards Community:

Treating parents with equal respect regardless of literacy levels; respecting indigenous customs; mobilizing community resources for school infrastructure.

3. Duty Towards the Profession:

Continuous pedagogical self-upgrading; resisting commercial private tutoring; displaying exemplary punctuality and intellectual integrity.

Mindfulness & The Neuroscience of Contemplative Stillness:

Mindfulness (derived from Buddhist *Sati* and Yogic *Smriti*) is defined by Dr. Jon Kabat-Zinn as paying attention in a particular way: on purpose, in the present moment, and non-judgmentally:

Neurobiological & Classroom Impact:

- **Structural Brain Changes:** MRI studies demonstrate that daily mindfulness thickens gray matter in the prefrontal cortex (executive attention) and shrinks the basolateral amygdala (fear and aggression centers).
- **Anapanasati Routine:** Introducing 2 minutes of quiet breathing at the beginning of each school day settles children's mental focus and reduces playground aggression.
- **Response Space (Viktor Frankl):** *"Between stimulus and response there is a space. In that space is our power to choose our response."* Mindfulness prevents automatic teacher yelling.

3

Reflective Seminars on Humane Qualities & Emotional Mastery

Carl Rogers' Humanism, Goleman's Emotional Intelligence, Social Grace & Self-Compassion

Weightage:
10 Marks (5 × 2)

American psychologist **Carl Rogers (1902–1987)** proved that meaningful cognitive learning cannot occur in an atmosphere of psychological intimidation, sarcasm, or conditional love. For transformational learning to unfold, the educator must embody **Three Core Attitudinal Conditions**:

1. UNCONDITIONAL POSITIVE REGARD (UPR)

Prizing and accepting the student as an intrinsically worthy human being, completely detached from their academic marks, neatness of clothes, or social background. The teacher communicates: *"You are valued here, regardless of your current academic mistakes."*

Condition: Zero Prerequisites for Acceptance

2. EMPATHETIC UNDERSTANDING

The capacity to grasp the student's private inner world as if it were one's own, without losing the "as-if" boundary. Sensing a child's terror during oral reading or confusion during math without judging them as lazy or defective.

Condition: Accurate Inner Perspective-Taking

3. CONGRUENCE / GENUINENESS

Being authentic, real, and transparent within the educational relationship. Dropping the defensive mask of the "infallible, all-knowing teacher". A congruent educator openly admits: *"I do not know the answer to that question; let us investigate it together."*

Condition: Real Self Matches Professed Self

Psychologist Daniel Goleman demonstrated that standard IQ (Intelligence Quotient) accounts for at most 20% of life and professional success; the remaining 80% is determined by **Emotional Intelligence (EQ)**. In teaching, where relational friction is constant, EQ determines whether an educator inspires students or burns out in frustration:

Domain 1

Self-Awareness

Recognizing emotional states, physical sensations, and mood shifts as they occur in real time in the classroom.

Domain 2

Self-Regulation

Managing disruptive emotional impulses; delaying gratification; responding intentionally rather than reacting with punitive anger.

Domain 3

Internal Motivation

Deep intrinsic drive to teach and inspire children, persisting through systemic obstacles beyond external paychecks or promotions.

Domain 4

Empathy

Reading unvocalized emotional cues, facial expressions, and somatic postures in students, understanding their developmental dilemmas.

Domain 5

Social Skills

Conflict de-escalation, inspiring leadership, clear and compassionate communication, and collaborative classroom management.

Real-Life Primary Classroom Demonstration:

When two Class 2 students get into a physical scuffle over a broken crayon, a teacher with low EQ reacts with punitive anger, shouting and slapping both children. An emotionally intelligent teacher steps in calmly, ensures physical safety, allows adrenaline to settle, validates feelings (*"I see you both feel very angry right now"*), and facilitates constructive dialogue to share materials.

3.3 &
3.4

Inculcating Social Grace, Soft Skills and Kristin Neff's Self-Compassion Framework

Relational
Competence

Soft Skills, Social Grace & Non-Verbal Modeling:

Children internalize social behavior primarily through observational modeling (Bandura) rather than verbal lectures:

- **Kinesics & Eye Contact:** Kneeling down to meet a primary child at their physical eye-level; using open hand gestures rather than accusatory finger-pointing.
- **Social Politeness & Modeling:** Consistently using polite language (*"Please"*, *"Thank you"*, *"Excuse me"*) when interacting with students, staff, and custodial cleaners alike.
- **Constructive "I-Statements":** Modeling conflict resolution using personal feelings rather than attacking labels (e.g., *"I feel overwhelmed when five people speak at once; let us take turns"* instead of *"You are all undisciplined children!"*).

Kristin Neff's Self-Compassion vs. Toxic Self-Criticism:

Novice teachers frequently oscillate between two psychological traps: toxic self-criticism (imposter syndrome) and fragile defensive vanity. Dr. Kristin Neff formulated **Self-Compassion** as a healthy alternative:

- **1. Self-Kindness vs. Self-Judgment:** Treating oneself with warmth, understanding, and forgiveness when pedagogical plans fail, rather than harsh internal condemnation.
- **2. Common Humanity vs. Isolation:** Recognizing that struggle, flawed lessons, and moments of pedagogical inadequacy are universal experiences shared by every teacher on Earth.
- **3. Mindfulness vs. Over-Identification:** Holding painful teaching episodes in balanced awareness without magnifying a single difficult day into evidence of personal worthlessness.

PAPER S1.4 CONTINUOUS INTERNAL ASSESSMENT ARCHITECTURE

Session
2026

Total: 50 Internal Marks • 100% Practical, Portfolio & Seminar-Based Evaluation

Unit 1: Reflective
Writings

**15 Marks (5 ×
3)**

Select Any 5
Introspective Tasks

Unit 2: Workshop
Reports

**15 Marks (5 ×
3)**

SWOT + Any 2
Workshops

Unit 3: Seminar
Papers

**10 Marks (5 ×
2)**

Paper & Defense on 2
Themes

SIP-I Field Delivery

10 Marks

Life Skills School
Implementation

Total Internal Assessment = 15 (Reflective Tasks) + 15 (Workshops) + 10 (Seminars) + 10 (SIP-I) = 50 Marks

PRESCRIBED PRACTICUM ACTIVITY REQUIREMENTS:

- **Reflective Journal Portfolio (15 Marks):** Maintain a continuous, weekly introspective journal documenting authentic pedagogical encounters, emotional dilemmas, self-efficacy reflections, and insights derived from educational thinkers.
- **Interactive Workshops & SWOT Portfolio (15 Marks):** Complete a structured Personal and Institutional SWOT Matrix; actively participate in Johari Window disclosure sessions; engage in daily morning assembly mindfulness and meditation drills.
- **Reflective Seminars (10 Marks):** Author and present two research-backed seminar monographs exploring humane qualities in teaching, Carl Rogers' humanism, or Daniel Goleman's emotional intelligence applications.
- **School Internship Linkage (SIP-I – 10 Marks):** During the 2-week school internship, facilitate at least three structured Life Skills games with primary students (focusing on communication, empathy, or conflict resolution) and compile an analytical reflection countersigned by the school head teacher.

EVALUATION PHILOSOPHY:

Faculty mentors evaluate Paper S1.4 not on rote theoretical memorization, but on the depth of the student-teacher's critical self-honesty, emotional vulnerability, empathy, constructiveness, and professional growth across the semester.

Paper S1.4 Master Study Notes • Curriculum Session 2026

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